

TEXAS ★ IN ★ ACTION

The Complete Assignment Guide

39 experiential assignments engaging Texas state and local government

GOVT 2306 · Complete/Incomplete rubrics · 100 points across at least two tiers

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How Texas In Action Works

- **100 points required** (40% of course grade), drawn from a 39-assignment menu worth 555 total points.
- **Category requirement:** activities from at least two different effort tiers.
- **Complete/Incomplete grading:** meet every rubric criterion → COMPLETE → full points. Miss any → specific feedback and one resubmission within one week.
- **AI-resistant by design:** every assignment demands your own districts, officials, tax records, photos, and conversations — verifiable local specifics that generic text cannot fake.
- **Never done local government before?** Every assignment includes a step-by-step How to Get Started guide. That's the point of the project.

Tier	Points	Count	Character
Higher Effort	20–30	12	Field work, investigations, interviews
Medium Effort	10–15	13	Focused research, observations, journals
Quick Engagement	5–8	14	Reflections, short videos, rapid lookups

Higher Effort Activities · 20–30 points each

1. Hidden Districts Investigation

30 POINTS · 4–5 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS CURIOUS WHY THEIR TAX BILL HAS SO MANY LINES ON IT

Texas has more than 3,000 special purpose districts — invisible governments that can tax you, charge you fees, take on debt in your name, and hold elections you've probably never voted in. Municipal Utility Districts (MUDs), Emergency Services Districts (ESDs), hospital districts, college districts, water districts, Public Improvement Districts (PIDs) — they layer over your home address like transparent sheets, and most Texans cannot name a single one they live in. Your mission: map every special purpose district that covers your home address, find out what each one charges you, who governs it, and whether you've ever had a say.

How to Get Started

1. Pull your property tax statement (or your family's, or your landlord's — for renters, your county appraisal district website lets you look up any address's taxing entities for free). In Tarrant County, go to TAD.org, search the address, and look at the "Taxing Entities" or "Jurisdictions" list.
2. For each entity that isn't the city, county, or ISD, look it up in the Comptroller's Special Purpose District Public Information Database (spdpid.comptroller.texas.gov). It lists board members, contact info, tax rates, and outstanding debt — all self-reported under state law.
3. Read pages 1–10 of "Invisible Government: Special Purpose Districts in Texas" (Texas Senate Research Center — free PDF, linked from comptroller.texas.gov/transparency/local/special-purpose.php).
4. If your address has few or no special districts (it happens), expand to your whole ZIP code or compare your address with a relative's or friend's address elsewhere in DFW.

Requirements

- Identify every taxing/fee-charging district covering your chosen address (minimum 4 entities total, including city/county/ISD if needed to reach 4)
- For each special purpose district: its purpose, governing board, current tax rate or fee structure, and outstanding debt (from SPDPID or the district's site)
- Calculate the combined annual cost of these districts for the property (use the appraisal district's value)
- Find out when the district's board elections are held and who is eligible to vote in them
- Written report (800 words minimum) including a "what surprised me" analysis
- Screenshot evidence from the appraisal district lookup and SPDPID

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 30 points

District Mapping ✓

- ☐ A real, specific address is used (street name may be redacted in the report; instructor verification available on request)
- ☐ Every taxing entity for that address is identified (minimum 4)
- ☐ Each special purpose district's type and legal purpose is correctly described
- ☐ Screenshot from county appraisal district jurisdiction lookup included
- ☐ Screenshot from SPDPID entry (or district website) for at least one district included

Financial Analysis ✓

- ☐ Current tax rate or fee structure documented for each district
- ☐ Combined annual cost calculated using the property's actual appraised value

- ☐ Outstanding debt reported for at least one district (or documented as zero/unreported)
- ☐ Math is shown and correct

Governance Analysis ✓

- ☐ Board members or governing structure identified for at least two districts
- ☐ Election timing and voter eligibility researched and reported
- ☐ Report addresses whether the student (or property owner) has ever voted in these elections

Written Report (800 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ "What surprised me" section shows genuine engagement, not generic statements
- ☐ Connects findings to course concepts (special districts, local government fragmentation, accountability)
- ☐ Specific names, numbers, and rates appear throughout (not vague summaries)

2. Commissioners Court Field Study

25 POINTS · 3–4 HOURS (INCLUDING MEETING TIME) · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO WANT TO SEE TEXAS'S MOST MISUNDERSTOOD GOVERNMENT IN ACTION

Despite the name, a commissioners court is not a court. It is the governing body of every one of Texas's 254 counties — a county judge plus four commissioners who together control the county budget, set the county tax rate, run the jail and county roads, oversee elections, and manage emergency response. It is arguably the most powerful local government you've never watched. Attend (in person or via official livestream/recording) one full commissioners court meeting and analyze what you saw.

How to Get Started

1. Find your county's commissioners court schedule. Tarrant County Commissioners Court typically meets Tuesday mornings — check tarrantcountytx.gov for the calendar, agendas, and the official video stream/archive. (Dallas, Denton, Johnson, and Parker counties all post theirs too — use your home county.)
2. Download the agenda before you watch. Agendas are posted at least 72 hours in advance under the Texas Open Meetings Act. Skim it and pick 2–3 items to track closely.
3. In person? Meetings are public — you can walk in. Arrive early, sit anywhere in the gallery, silence your phone. Streaming? Live or archived official video both count, but you must watch a complete recent meeting (within the current semester).

Requirements

- Attend or stream one complete commissioners court meeting from the current semester
- Proof of engagement: a photo of you at the meeting OR timestamped screenshots from the stream at three different points
- The agenda (saved/linked) with your 2–3 tracked items marked
- Written analysis (700 words minimum) covering: who the county judge and commissioners are (by name and precinct), what was decided on your tracked items, how the meeting blends legislative and executive functions, and one budget or tax item discussed
- Identify which commissioner represents your precinct

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 25 points

Attendance & Documentation ✓

- ☐ Complete meeting from current semester attended or streamed

- ☐ Photo at meeting OR three timestamped screenshots provided
- ☐ Agenda included with tracked items clearly marked
- ☐ Meeting is a genuine commissioners court (not city council or other body)

Knowledge of the Court ✓

- ☐ County judge and all four commissioners named correctly
- ☐ Student's own precinct and commissioner identified
- ☐ The court's hybrid legislative/executive nature explained with a specific example from the meeting

Analysis (700 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ 2–3 tracked agenda items summarized with outcomes
- ☐ At least one budget, contract, or tax-related item analyzed
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (county government structure, plural executive at the local level, Open Meetings Act)
- ☐ Includes specific quotes, votes, or moments only attainable by actually watching

3. The Data Center Reckoning

30 POINTS · 4–5 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS INTERESTED IN TECHNOLOGY, ENERGY, WATER, OR WHERE THE ECONOMY IS HEADED

Texas is in the middle of a data center boom — and DFW is its epicenter. These facilities consume enormous electricity and water, receive local tax incentives, and are reshaping the grid so fast that the Legislature passed Senate Bill 6 (2025) giving ERCOT new powers over "large loads," including a remote-disconnect requirement critics call the "kill switch." Meanwhile, data centers are *excluded* from the state's flagship JETI school-tax incentive — but can still receive local Chapter 312 property tax abatements and a state sales tax exemption. Investigate one real data center project in Texas (DFW alone offers dozens) and produce an impact report: who approved it, what incentives it received, what it demands from the grid and water supply, and who bears the costs and benefits.

How to Get Started

1. Pick a project. Search local news (Fort Worth Report, Dallas Morning News, Star-Telegram, Dallas Business Journal) for "data center" plus a city name — Fort Worth, Arlington, Lancaster, Red Oak, Garland, and Abilene have all had major announcements. Pick one with public records.
2. Find the local government trail. Search the city council and/or commissioners court agendas/minutes for the project or company name. Look for zoning cases, Chapter 312/380 agreements, water/infrastructure deals.
3. Check the incentive databases. The Comptroller's Chapter 312 abatement and Chapter 380/381 agreement databases (comptroller.texas.gov → Transparency → Local) list registered agreements.
4. Understand SB 6. Read at least one substantive explainer on SB 6's requirements for 75 MW+ loads (interconnection fees, disclosure, remote disconnect, curtailment).

Requirements

- One specific, named, real Texas data center project documented
- The local approval trail: which government bodies voted on what, and when (agendas/minutes cited)
- Any incentives identified (Chapter 312/380, sales tax exemption eligibility) — or documented absence of incentives
- Estimated power and/or water demand from credible reporting
- Explanation of how SB 6 applies (or doesn't) to this facility
- Written report (900 words minimum) with a balanced costs/benefits assessment for the host community

- Minimum 5 credible sources, cited

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 30 points

Project Documentation ✓

- ☐ A real, specific Texas data center project is the subject
- ☐ Local government approval trail traced with at least one agenda, minutes document, or official record cited
- ☐ Approving bodies correctly identified (city council, commissioners court, school board, etc.)

Incentives & Law ✓

- ☐ Incentive status researched and accurately reported (Chapter 312/380, sales tax exemption, JETI exclusion noted)
- ☐ SB 6's relevance explained correctly (75 MW threshold, disclosure, remote disconnect/curtailment)
- ☐ Distinction between state and local incentive authority is clear

Impact Analysis ✓

- ☐ Power and/or water demand figures included from credible reporting
- ☐ Benefits to host community identified (tax base, jobs, infrastructure)
- ☐ Costs/risks identified (grid strain, water, noise/land use, abatement revenue foregone)
- ☐ Assessment is balanced, not one-sided

Report Quality (900 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Minimum 5 credible sources cited
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (local economic development, special districts/utilities, state regulatory power)
- ☐ Specific dollar figures, dates, and names throughout

4. Public Comment in Texas

25 POINTS · 3–4 HOURS (INCLUDING MEETING) · BEST FOR: STUDENTS READY TO PARTICIPATE, NOT JUST OBSERVE

Texas law guarantees your right to address local governing bodies. Deliver a public comment — on an issue you actually care about — at a city council, school board, or commissioners court meeting in Texas.

How to Get Started

1. Pick your body and issue. Fort Worth City Council, your home city's council, your ISD's board, or your county's commissioners court. Pick an issue genuinely connected to your life: streets, housing, school policy, parks, public safety, library hours — anything within that body's actual authority.
2. Learn the sign-up procedure. Every body posts its public comment rules: some require online sign-up by a deadline (Fort Worth uses an online speaker card system), some have sign-up sheets at the door. Time limits are typically 2–3 minutes. Call the city secretary's office if the website is unclear — that phone call is itself civic engagement.
3. Write and rehearse. 2–3 minutes is roughly 250–350 words. State who you are, what you're asking for, and why — respectfully and specifically.
4. Anxiety accommodation: If speaking is a genuine barrier, written comments formally submitted into the record (where the body accepts them) qualify — document the submission.

Requirements

- Research the issue with at least 2 credible sources
- Written transcript of your prepared comment (within the body's time limit)

- Deliver the comment at a legitimate Texas governing body meeting
- Proof: video clip, meeting video timestamp, sign-in confirmation, or official minutes listing you
- Reflection (500 words minimum): the procedure you navigated, how officials responded, what you'd do differently

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 25 points

Preparation ✓

- ☐ Issue researched with minimum 2 credible sources
- ☐ Issue falls within the body's actual jurisdiction
- ☐ Comment transcript provided, within time limit, respectful and specific
- ☐ Clear position or request stated

Delivery & Documentation ✓

- ☐ Comment delivered at a legitimate Texas government body meeting (or written comment formally submitted with documentation, if accommodation applies)
- ☐ Proof of participation provided
- ☐ Sign-up/registration procedure described accurately

Reflection (500 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Describes officials' response (or lack thereof)
- ☐ Evaluates accessibility of the public comment process honestly
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (participation, representation, responsiveness)

5. School Finance: Follow the Money

25 POINTS · 3–4 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WITH KIDS IN SCHOOL, STUDENTS WHO WENT TO TEXAS PUBLIC SCHOOLS, FUTURE EDUCATORS

Texas school finance is famously labyrinthine: a "basic allotment" the Legislature raised by only \$55 in 2025 (the first increase since 2019), a "recapture" system (nicknamed Robin Hood) that pulls money from property-wealthy districts, billion-dollar local bond elections, and now school-district tax abatements for industry. Pick one Texas ISD you have a personal connection to and follow its money.

How to Get Started

1. Pick your ISD (where you attended, where your kids attend, or where you live — e.g., Fort Worth ISD, Crowley ISD, Arlington ISD, Keller ISD).
2. Find the budget. Every ISD posts an adopted budget and tax rate on its website (search "[district name] adopted budget"). TEA's website also publishes district financial data.
3. Check recapture status. Search "[district] recapture" or look in the budget documents — does your district pay into recapture or receive state aid?
4. Find the last bond election. Search "[district] bond election" — what was proposed, what passed, what's the debt?

Requirements

- One specific ISD with your stated personal connection
- The district's current total tax rate, broken into M&O and I&S components, explained in plain English
- The district's per-student funding picture, referencing the basic allotment and HB 2 (2025) changes

- Recapture status documented (payer, recipient of state aid, or neither — with numbers if available)
- The most recent bond election: amount, purpose, result, current outstanding debt
- Written report (800 words minimum) answering: "Who really funds my district, and who decides?"

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 25 points

District Facts ✓

- ☐ Specific ISD identified with genuine personal connection stated
- ☐ Current tax rate found and correctly split into M&O and I&S
- ☐ Budget document or TEA data cited (link or screenshot)

Finance System Understanding ✓

- ☐ Basic allotment and HB 2 (2025) changes accurately described
- ☐ Recapture explained correctly and district's status documented
- ☐ State vs. local funding shares addressed

Bond & Debt ✓

- ☐ Most recent bond election documented (amount, purpose, outcome)
- ☐ Outstanding debt reported or documented as unavailable

Report Quality (800 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Central question answered with evidence
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (fiscal federalism within Texas, local control, school governance)
- ☐ Real numbers from the actual district throughout

6. Local Official Interview Series

25 POINTS · 4–5 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO LEARN THROUGH CONVERSATION

Interview two different people who work in or for Texas local government — elected or staff. Justices of the peace, constables, city council members, school trustees, city planners, county clerks, election administrators, firefighters in an ESD, librarians, code compliance officers — the menu is enormous, and most are far more accessible than students expect.

How to Get Started

1. Aim local and aim realistic. A school board trustee or JP is far more reachable than the mayor of Fort Worth. Official emails are public on city/county websites. A polite email mentioning you're a TCC government student requesting 15–20 minutes works remarkably often.
2. Two different roles — ideally one elected official and one government employee, or two different levels (city + county).
3. Prepare 6–8 questions per interview about their actual work: What does your office really do? What do residents misunderstand? How does state law constrain you? What decision are you proudest of?
4. Phone, video, or in-person all count. Record only with permission, or take detailed notes.

Requirements

- Two interviews, different people, different roles, both connected to Texas state or local government
- Question lists submitted for both
- Documentation: recording (with permission), detailed notes, or confirmation emails plus notes

- Comparative analysis (800 words minimum): what each role actually does, how state law shapes their work, what surprised you, how the two roles differ

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 25 points

Interview Execution ✓

- ☐ Two real interviews with two different people in different government roles
- ☐ Both roles are genuinely Texas state or local government (elected or staff)
- ☐ 6–8 prepared questions per interview submitted
- ☐ Documentation provided for both (recording, notes, and/or correspondence)

Substance ✓

- ☐ Each official's actual duties accurately described
- ☐ At least one example per interview of how Texas state law shapes or limits their work
- ☐ Specific quotes or paraphrased moments from each conversation

Comparative Analysis (800 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Meaningful comparison between the two roles
- ☐ "What surprised me" reflection is specific and genuine
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (county vs. municipal structure, elected vs. appointed, decentralization)

7. Texas Services Directory

30 POINTS · 5–6 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO WANT TO CREATE SOMETHING GENUINELY USEFUL

Build a practical guide to government services in your community — the document you wish someone had handed you (or your family) years ago. Minimum 15 services across city, county, special district, and state levels, each verified and explained for a real person who needs it.

How to Get Started

1. Choose your community (your city or your part of Fort Worth/Arlington/etc.).
2. Brainstorm from life: registering a car (county tax assessor-collector), CHIP/Medicaid (state HHSC), a pothole (city), a property tax exemption (appraisal district), voter registration (county elections), small claims (JP court), restaurant complaints (city/county health), unemployment (TWC), mental health crisis (local MHMR authority — MyHealthMyResources in Tarrant County), library cards, animal control, burn bans...
3. Verify each entry: correct office, current contact info, what to bring, cost, and the actual web link. Call or check the site — directories die when their info is wrong.

Requirements

- Minimum 15 services spanning at least: 4 city, 4 county, 2 special district, 3 state
- Each entry: service name, responsible government + office, contact info, how to access (steps), cost, verified link
- Each entry labeled by level of government
- Introduction (200 words) explaining how to use the directory and what you learned building it
- Format usable by a real person (organized document, table, or webpage)

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 30 points

Coverage ✓

- ☐ Minimum 15 services included
- ☐ Distribution met: ≥ 4 city, ≥ 4 county, ≥ 2 special district, ≥ 3 state
- ☐ Each entry correctly labeled by level of government

Accuracy & Usability ✓

- ☐ Responsible office correctly identified for every entry
- ☐ Current contact info and working links verified
- ☐ Access steps are concrete (what to bring, where to go, what it costs)
- ☐ Organized, readable format a neighbor could actually use

Reflection & Connection ✓

- ☐ 200-word introduction included
- ☐ Reflection identifies which level of government surprised the student most
- ☐ Demonstrates understanding of which level handles what (and why that's confusing)

8. Local Control vs. State Preemption

25 POINTS · 3–4 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS DRAWN TO POLITICAL CONFLICT AND CONSTITUTIONAL QUESTIONS

Texas celebrates local control — except when the Legislature doesn't. In 2023 lawmakers passed HB 2127, the "Texas Regulatory Consistency Act" (opponents call it the "Death Star Bill"), sweeping away local ordinances across whole fields of law. Cities sued; a district court declared it unconstitutional; the state's appeal kept the law in effect while courts wrestle with it. And HB 2127 is just the biggest example — Texas has preempted local rules on plastic bags, fracking, short-term rentals, paid sick leave, and more. Pick one specific state-vs-local conflict (HB 2127 itself, or a narrower fight) and analyze it from both sides.

How to Get Started

1. Pick your conflict. Options: HB 2127 broadly; Denton's 2014 fracking ban and HB 40; the plastic bag ordinance fight (City of Laredo case); short-term rental battles; a current Fort Worth/Arlington/Dallas example from local news.
2. Get the basics from quality sources: Texas Tribune, Texas Municipal League, court filings, the bill text on capitol.texas.gov.
3. Find the current status — especially for HB 2127, where litigation is ongoing. Your report must state the legal status *as of your submission date*, with a source.

Requirements

- One specific, named conflict with the relevant bill/ordinance/case identified
- Accurate timeline of the conflict
- The strongest version of BOTH arguments: state uniformity/business climate vs. home rule/local democracy
- Current legal status as of submission, sourced
- Connection to the Texas Constitution's home rule provision (Art. XI, Sec. 5)
- Written analysis (800 words minimum) ending with your own assessed position

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 25 points

Case Facts ✓

- ☐ Specific conflict chosen with bill numbers/ordinances/cases correctly cited
- ☐ Timeline accurate

- ☐ Current legal status stated as of submission date with source

Two-Sided Analysis ✓

- ☐ State's strongest arguments presented fairly
☐ Cities'/local strongest arguments presented fairly
☐ Home rule (Art. XI, Sec. 5) correctly explained and applied

Written Analysis (800 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
☐ Student's own position stated and defended with evidence
☐ Connects to course concepts (home rule vs. general law cities, Dillon's Rule tensions, federalism analogies)
☐ Minimum 4 credible sources cited

9. Track a Texas Law

25 POINTS · 3–4 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO WANT TO SEE HOW A BILL BECOMES (AND BECOMES FELT AS) A LAW

Pick one bill from a recent Texas legislative session that affects local communities, and follow it from filing to real-world implementation. Because the Legislature meets in regular session only in odd-numbered years, this assignment works in any semester: in session years you can track a live bill; in interim years you trace a recently passed law's implementation (often the more interesting story).

How to Get Started

1. Choose a bill with local impact. Strong candidates from the 89th session (2025): SB 6 (data centers/grid), HB 2 (school finance), or any bill covered by local news. Or pick from the 88th (2023): HB 2127 (preemption), HB 3 (school safety/armed officers).
2. Use Texas Legislature Online (capitol.texas.gov): search the bill number, read the bill analysis (plain-English summary), check the actions list (committee, votes, signing), and watch at least 15 minutes of archived committee testimony on the bill.
3. Find the local landing. How is YOUR city, county, school district, or a local agency implementing or responding to this law? Search local news and local government agendas.

Requirements

- One bill, correctly cited (number, session, author)
- Legislative journey documented from TLO: committee(s), key votes, governor's action
- At least 15 minutes of archived committee hearing video watched, with notes on 2 specific witnesses/exchanges
- Local implementation evidence: how a specific local government or agency near you is affected
- Written report (800 words minimum)

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 25 points

Legislative Tracking ✓

- ☐ Bill correctly identified (number, session, author)
☐ Path through committees and floor votes accurately summarized from TLO
☐ Governor's action (signed/vetoed/no signature) and effective date correct

Testimony Engagement ✓

- ☐ 15+ minutes of archived committee video watched
☐ Notes on at least 2 specific witnesses or member exchanges (names/affiliations)

- ☐ Testimony's influence (or futility) assessed

Local Implementation ✓

- ☐ Specific local government/agency identified as affected
☐ Concrete implementation evidence cited (agenda item, news report, policy change)

Report Quality (800 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
☐ Connects to course concepts (legislative process, biennial sessions, implementation gap)
☐ Sources cited

10. Property Tax Autopsy

25 POINTS · 3–4 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHOSE FAMILIES OWN PROPERTY — OR WHO WANT TO UNDERSTAND WHY RENT KEEPS RISING

Texas has no state income tax, which means property taxes do the heavy lifting — and the system (appraisal districts, exemptions, rate-setting, truth-in-taxation hearings) is a complete mystery to most people paying it. Dissect a real property tax statement line by line, and observe rate-setting in action.

How to Get Started

1. Get a statement. Yours, family's, or — for renters — look up your apartment complex or any address on your county appraisal district site (TAD.org in Tarrant; all records are public).
2. Decode every line: each taxing entity, its rate, the appraised vs. taxable value, and every exemption applied (homestead, over-65, disabled veteran...). The Comptroller's property tax pages explain each exemption.
3. Truth-in-taxation: find your county's tax rate notice site (Texas counties must post proposed rates, no-new-revenue rates, and hearing dates — many use a "tax transparency" portal). Watch or attend one tax rate hearing OR read the official notice and minutes for the most recent one.
4. Bonus understanding: note the difference between the appraisal district (sets values) and taxing units (set rates) — most Texans conflate them.

Requirements

- A real statement or appraisal-district record analyzed (sensitive details may be redacted)
- Every line item explained: entity, rate, what it funds
- Appraised vs. taxable value and all exemptions explained; if no exemptions, explain which could apply
- Truth-in-taxation component: one taxing unit's most recent rate adoption documented (proposed vs. no-new-revenue rate, hearing date, outcome)
- The appraisal district vs. taxing unit distinction explained correctly
- Written report (700 words minimum) including: "If I wanted to lower this bill, what are my actual legal options?" (exemptions, protest by May 15 or 30 days after notice, showing up at rate hearings)

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 25 points

Statement Dissection ✓

- ☐ Real statement/record used (screenshot or scan, redaction allowed)
☐ Every taxing entity and rate identified and explained
☐ Appraised vs. taxable value distinction handled correctly
☐ Exemptions explained (applied or potentially applicable)

Rate-Setting & Process ✓

- ☐ One taxing unit's most recent rate adoption documented with proposed vs. no-new-revenue comparison
- ☐ Appraisal district vs. taxing units distinction correctly explained
- ☐ Protest process accurately described (deadline: May 15 or 30 days after notice; ARB; Form 50-132)

Report Quality (700 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ "Legal options" section is accurate and specific
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (local revenue, truth-in-taxation, no state income tax tradeoff)
- ☐ Real numbers from the actual record throughout

11. Disaster-Ready Community Audit

25 POINTS · 3–4 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS MOTIVATED BY KEEPING THEIR FAMILY AND NEIGHBORS SAFE

When disaster hits Texas — tornado, flood, ice storm, grid emergency — a specific local machinery activates: the county emergency management office, city emergency plans, Emergency Services Districts, outdoor warning sirens, alert systems, and shelters. Most residents discover this machinery only mid-crisis. Audit your community's emergency preparedness infrastructure before you need it.

How to Get Started

1. Find your county's office of emergency management (Tarrant County OEM, or your county's) and your city's emergency management page.
2. Sign up for your local emergency alert system and document it (most Tarrant-area jurisdictions use a county/city alert registration; your county OEM page links it).
3. Map the local hazards: what does your county's hazard mitigation plan or OEM page identify as top risks? (In North Texas: tornadoes, flash floods, winter storms, extreme heat.)
4. Identify your nearest resources: outdoor warning sirens policy (when do they sound?), nearest designated shelter or cooling/warming station, who provides fire/EMS at your address (city department or an ESD — check your tax entities!).
5. Build your household plan using the state's ready.texas.gov framework (TDEM).

Requirements

- County and city emergency management offices identified with their actual responsibilities
- Proof of alert system registration (screenshot)
- Top 3 local hazards identified from official sources
- Fire/EMS provider for your address identified (city dept. or named ESD)
- Outdoor warning siren policy for your jurisdiction explained
- A completed written household emergency plan (TDEM/ready.texas.gov framework)
- Reflection (600 words minimum): what existed that you didn't know about, and one gap you identified

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 25 points

Government Infrastructure Mapping ✓

- ☐ County OEM and city emergency management correctly identified with roles
- ☐ Fire/EMS provider for student's address correctly identified
- ☐ Siren policy accurately described for their jurisdiction
- ☐ Top 3 hazards drawn from official local sources

Personal Preparedness Actions ✓

- ☐ Alert registration screenshot provided
- ☐ Household emergency plan completed using TDEM framework
- ☐ Nearest shelter/cooling/warming resource identified

Reflection (600 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Identifies a specific genuine gap (personal or governmental)
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (intergovernmental coordination, ESDs, state TDEM role)

12. Texas Myth Busting Video

20 POINTS · 3–4 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO LIKE CREATING MEDIA AND CORRECTING THE RECORD

Texans believe a lot of things about Texas government that aren't true: *"Texas can legally secede." "The governor runs everything." "Texas has no taxes." "The Texas Rangers can overrule local police." "Property taxes go to the state."* Pick two myths, research the truth, and produce a 3–5 minute myth-busting video built for your generation.

How to Get Started

1. Pick two myths — from the list above, from your own family group chat, or propose your own (clear it with your instructor if unsure).
2. Research each: what people believe, where the myth comes from, and what's actually true — with authoritative sources (Texas Constitution, statutes, Comptroller, court decisions, Texas Tribune explainers).
3. Script and film. Phone video is fine. Show your face for at least part of it. Visual aids (screenshots of the Constitution, charts) strengthen it.

Requirements

- 3–5 minute video, two myths busted
- Your face/voice present (not pure slideshow with stock narration)
- Each myth: statement of belief → origin/why people believe it → documented truth → why it matters
- Minimum 4 credible sources, listed on screen or in submission
- Written source list with 1–2 sentences on each source's credibility

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 20 points

Video Requirements ✓

- ☐ 3–5 minutes, clear audio/video
- ☐ Student's own face and voice present
- ☐ Two distinct Texas government myths addressed

Accuracy ✓

- ☐ Each myth's actual truth documented correctly
- ☐ Minimum 4 credible sources used and listed
- ☐ Origins of each myth addressed
- ☐ No new misinformation introduced

Presentation & Reflection ✓

- ☐ Engaging, organized format with visual support
- ☐ "Why it matters" explained for each myth

☐ Written source credibility notes submitted

Medium Effort Activities · 10–15 points each

13. Find Your Five Governments

15 POINTS · 2–3 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO LIKE A CHALLENGE THEY CAN DO WHILE LIVING THEIR NORMAL LIFE

A photo scavenger hunt with a thesis: at least five distinct governments touch your daily life, and you're going to prove it. Not five government *things* — five different *governments* (your city, your county, your ISD, a special district, a state agency, a community college district...).

How to Get Started

1. Think in jurisdictions, not buildings. A fire hydrant might be city; the road might be county or TxDOT; the school is an ISD; the hospital district sign, the water tower with a MUD name, the TCC campus (a college district with its own taxing authority!), the TxDOT highway sign, the game warden's truck (TPWD), the state inspection...
2. Photograph each over the course of a week or two — original photos, taken by you, with you or a personal landmark in at least two of them.
3. Verify the jurisdiction. The whole point is correctly attributing each photo: "this is Tarrant County's, not Fort Worth's, because..."

Requirements

- 5 original photos, each representing a DIFFERENT government entity
- At least 2 different *types* (municipal, county, school district, special district, state agency)
- Caption per photo: the entity, what the photographed thing is, and how you verified which government owns/runs it
- Summary reflection (300 words): what this exercise revealed about overlapping governments

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 15 points

Photo Documentation ✓

- ☐ 5 original photos taken by the student
- ☐ 5 genuinely different government entities represented
- ☐ At least 2 different types of government included
- ☐ Photos are local to the student's actual life/area

Attribution Accuracy ✓

- ☐ Each caption correctly identifies the responsible government
- ☐ Verification method stated for each ("I checked the city's street directory," "the sign says ESD No. 1," etc.)
- ☐ No misattributed entities

Reflection (300 words) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Addresses fragmentation/overlap of local government in Texas
- ☐ Connects to course concepts

14. Fix My Street

12 POINTS · 1.5–2 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO PASS THE SAME POTHOLE, DEAD STREETLIGHT, OR BUSTED SIDEWALK EVERY SINGLE DAY

The pothole on your street, the streetlight that's been out for months, the sidewalk that ends in rubble, the missing stop sign — somebody is responsible for fixing each one, and there is an official channel for making them do it. Most residents never learn which government owns which problem or how to file a request that actually gets tracked. You will. Identify a real infrastructure problem in your community, figure out exactly which government is responsible, and report it through the official channel — then document what happens.

How to Get Started

1. Find your issue. You almost certainly already know one: pothole, streetlight, sidewalk, drainage, illegal dumping, faded signage, dangerous intersection. Photograph it.
2. Figure out whose problem it is — this is the hard, valuable part. The same street can change owners block to block: city street (city public works/transportation), county road (your commissioners precinct office maintains it), state highway or frontage road (TxDOT), private street (HOA — also a finding!). Streetlights are often the electric utility (Oncor has its own outage-report tool) even when the city requests them. Check your city's street directory, your county's precinct road pages, or call and ask — being redirected twice is data, not failure.
3. Use the official channel. Fort Worth uses the MyFW app/311 system; most cities have an online service request portal or 311 line; counties take road issues through the commissioner precinct office; TxDOT and Oncor have report forms. File the request and screenshot your confirmation/tracking number.
4. Follow up. Check the request status before submitting this assignment. Fixed, scheduled, acknowledged, or ignored — all are reportable outcomes.

Requirements

- One real, photographed infrastructure issue in the student's own community
- Correct responsible government/entity identified, with the verification trail explained (including any redirections)
- Official report filed through the proper channel, with confirmation/tracking screenshot
- Status check documented before submission (response, timeline, or silence)
- Write-up (400 words minimum): the process, how findable the right channel was, and what this reveals about responsiveness and fragmented responsibility

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 12 points

Issue & Attribution ✓

- ☐ Real local issue documented with the student's own photo
- ☐ Responsible government/entity correctly identified
- ☐ Verification trail explained (how the student ruled out the other candidates)

Official Action ✓

- ☐ Report filed through the correct official channel
- ☐ Confirmation/tracking number or submission screenshot provided
- ☐ Status checked and outcome documented before submission

Write-Up (400 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Honest assessment of how accessible the process was
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (service delivery, fragmented jurisdiction, government responsiveness)

15. Courtroom Texas: JP or Municipal Court Observation

15 POINTS · 2-3 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS CURIOUS ABOUT THE JUSTICE SYSTEM MOST TEXANS ACTUALLY ENCOUNTER

Forget Law & Order — the courts most Texans experience are justice of the peace courts (small claims up to \$20,000, evictions, truancy, traffic) and municipal courts (city ordinance violations, Class C misdemeanors). Observe a session of one and analyze what justice looks like at this level.

How to Get Started

1. Find a court. Tarrant County has multiple JP precincts (tarrantcountytexas.gov lists them with dockets); every incorporated city has a municipal court. Call ahead or check the website for public docket times — eviction and small claims dockets are typically open to the public.
2. Show up early, dress respectfully, silence your phone. You may be asked your business at the door; "I'm a TCC government student observing for a class assignment" is a perfectly good answer.
3. No photos/recording in the courtroom. Document attendance with a photo outside the courthouse/courtroom and detailed contemporaneous notes.

Requirements

- Attend at least 60 minutes of live proceedings (JP or municipal court) in Texas
- Photo outside the building + detailed notes as proof
- Identify the judge and the court's jurisdiction (what kinds of cases it CAN hear)
- Notes on at least 3 matters heard (anonymize parties)
- Reflection (500 words minimum): how this court differs from TV courts, who appeared with/without lawyers, what "access to justice" looked like

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 15 points

Observation & Documentation ✓

- ☐ 60+ minutes of live JP or municipal court observed
- ☐ Photo and detailed notes provided
- ☐ Judge and court correctly identified
- ☐ Court's jurisdiction accurately described

Case Notes ✓

- ☐ At least 3 matters summarized (anonymized)
- ☐ Procedure observed accurately (informality, representation, outcomes)

Reflection (500 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Addresses representation and access-to-justice observations
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (Texas court structure, local trial courts)

16. Appraisal Protest Exercise

12 POINTS · 2 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHOSE FAMILIES OWN PROPERTY, OR FUTURE HOMEOWNERS

■■ THIS IS AN EXERCISE — DO NOT FILE ANYTHING. You will prepare a complete, hearing-ready protest packet, but you will NOT submit Form 50-132 to the appraisal district. Filing a protest is a real legal action that only the property owner (or their authorized agent) may take. Every document you produce for this assignment must be clearly marked "CLASS EXERCISE — NOT FILED" across the top. If your family happens to be protesting for real this year, you may document that authentic process instead — but the default for everyone is the exercise. Every Texas property owner has the right to protest their appraised value — deadline May 15 or 30 days after the appraisal notice, whichever is later — with a hearing before a citizen Appraisal Review Board. Most owners never use this right because they don't know how. Walk through the entire process, start to finish, so that you do. There's also a civics puzzle buried in here, and your write-up must engage it: protesting is a legitimate individual check on government power — but appraised values fund schools, counties, cities, and hospital districts. If every protest succeeds, the tax base shrinks, and governments must either raise rates (triggering truth-in-taxation requirements) or cut services. The individual incentive and the collective consequence pull in opposite directions. That tension IS Texas government.

How to Get Started

1. Pick a real property (family's, or any property — records are public on your county appraisal district site).
2. Pull the property's appraisal record and at least 3 comparable properties from the same neighborhood on the appraisal district site.
3. Get Form 50-132 (Notice of Protest) from the Comptroller's site or your CAD. Fill it out completely — then write "CLASS EXERCISE — NOT FILED" across it. Do not mail it, upload it, or submit it through any portal.
4. Build the evidence packet: comparables table, photos/condition notes if applicable, and the value you'd argue for.
5. (Only if your family is genuinely protesting this year, with the owner's involvement: you may document the real filing and, if timing allows, the informal review or ARB hearing instead.)

Requirements

- Real property record + 3 comparables documented from the CAD website
- Completed Form 50-132 marked "CLASS EXERCISE — NOT FILED" (or documentation of a genuine family protest)
- Evidence packet with a specific proposed value and reasoning
- Correct explanation of the timeline (notice → protest deadline → informal review → ARB hearing → further appeals)
- Write-up (500 words minimum) addressing BOTH: (a) how accessible is this process to a working person, and (b) the trade-off — if protests succeed at scale, which local governments and services lose revenue, and what are their options?

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 12 points

Records & Evidence ✓

- ☐ Real property record and 3 genuine comparables included (screenshots)
- ☐ Comparables are reasonably comparable (same area/type)
- ☐ Proposed value stated with reasoning

Process Mastery & Exercise Discipline ✓

- ☐ Form 50-132 completed correctly AND clearly marked "CLASS EXERCISE — NOT FILED" (or genuine protest documented with owner's involvement)

- ☐ Nothing was actually filed in the exercise version
- ☐ Timeline and deadline stated accurately (May 15 / 30 days after notice)
- ☐ ARB's role correctly described

Write-Up (500 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Accessibility assessment is thoughtful
- ☐ Trade-off analysis included: identifies which taxing entities lose revenue if values fall and what their realistic responses are (rate increases under truth-in-taxation, service cuts)
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (appraisal districts, ARBs, taxpayer remedies, local revenue dependence)

17. Local Ballot Breakdown

12 POINTS · 1.5–2 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO'VE STARED AT A BALLOT'S BOTTOM HALF IN CONFUSION

Texas ballots are marathons — and the most consequential races are often the ones nobody researches: school board, city council, bond propositions, constitutional amendments. Decode a real, recent or upcoming ballot for YOUR address and produce a plain-English voter guide.

How to Get Started

1. Get your actual ballot. Your county elections site posts sample ballots by precinct (Tarrant: tarrantcountytx.gov/elections). Use the most recent election OR an upcoming one. Vote411.org and the League of Women Voters guides help with candidate info.
2. Pick the local section: at least 5 local items (races below the statewide level and/or propositions).
3. For each item: what the office/proposition actually does, who's running or what a YES/NO means, and where to find more.

Requirements

- Real sample ballot for the student's own precinct (screenshot/link)
- Minimum 5 local items decoded
- For bond/amendment propositions: plain-English translation of the legalese plus fiscal impact
- Honest "what I would need to know to vote well here" note per item
- Reflection (300 words): why down-ballot turnout collapses and what that means for who governs locally

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 12 points

Ballot Work ✓

- ☐ Student's actual precinct ballot used and documented
- ☐ 5+ local items decoded accurately
- ☐ Propositions translated into plain English with fiscal impact where applicable

Quality ✓

- ☐ Offices' actual powers described correctly
- ☐ Sources for candidate/proposition info identified
- ☐ Guide would genuinely help a confused neighbor

Reflection (300 words) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Engages with ballot roll-off/turnout and local power

☐ Connects to course concepts

18. County Budget Explorer

12 POINTS · 2 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO WANT TO KNOW WHERE THE MONEY ACTUALLY GOES

Your county's budget is a moral document with line items. Explore your county's current adopted budget and report where the money comes from and where it goes — including the items that surprise you (the jail is usually the big one).

How to Get Started

1. Find the adopted budget on your county's website (search "[county] adopted budget" — Tarrant County posts current and past budgets with summaries).
2. You don't need to read 400 pages. Use the budget summary / budget-in-brief sections: total size, major revenue sources, largest departments.
3. Pick 3 line items to investigate more closely — at least one related to public safety/jail and one you'd never have guessed existed.

Requirements

- Current adopted county budget located (link + screenshot of summary page)
- Total budget size, top 3 revenue sources, top 5 spending categories reported
- 3 line items investigated with what-it-funds explanations
- Comparison: jail/public safety spending vs. one other major category
- Write-up (450 words minimum)

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 12 points

Budget Facts ✓

- ☐ Current adopted budget for student's county used
- ☐ Totals, revenue sources, and spending categories accurately reported
- ☐ Screenshots/links provided

Investigation ✓

- ☐ 3 specific line items explained (incl. one public-safety/jail item)
- ☐ Comparison performed with actual figures
- ☐ Numbers are correct and sourced

Write-Up (450 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Surprise findings genuine and specific
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (county functions, commissioners court budget power)

19. ERCOT & You

12 POINTS · 2 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO WANT TO UNDERSTAND THE MOST TEXAN THING ABOUT TEXAS: ITS OWN POWER GRID

Texas runs its own electric grid (ERCOT) precisely to avoid federal regulation — a choice with enormous consequences for reliability, prices, and now the data center boom. Map the governance of YOUR electricity: who generates it, who delivers it, who sells it to you, and who regulates each layer.

How to Get Started

1. Identify your layers. In most of DFW: ERCOT operates the grid; Oncor delivers (the wires); a retail electric provider sells to you (you chose it — or your landlord did); the PUC regulates; the Legislature oversees. (Some students will be in a municipally owned utility or co-op — Denton, Garland, Tri-County EC — which is a different and equally interesting answer.)
2. Pull a real electric bill and identify the delivery charges vs. energy charges.
3. Visit ERCOT's real-time dashboard (ercot.com) and screenshot current grid conditions (demand, capacity).
4. If you have retail choice: compare your current plan against 2 alternatives on powertochoose.org.

Requirements

- All governance layers for the student's own electricity correctly mapped
- Real bill decoded (delivery vs. energy charges; redact account info)
- ERCOT dashboard screenshot with a one-paragraph explanation of what it shows
- Retail choice comparison (or explanation of why student doesn't have retail choice — muni/co-op)
- Write-up (450 words minimum) including one sentence on how SB 6 (2025) changed large-load rules and why that matters for grid reliability

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 12 points

Governance Mapping ✓

- ☐ ERCOT, transmission/delivery utility, retail provider (or muni/co-op), PUC roles all correctly identified for the student's own service
- ☐ Why Texas has its own grid explained accurately

Personal Evidence ✓

- ☐ Real bill decoded with screenshots
- ☐ ERCOT dashboard screenshot + accurate explanation
- ☐ Retail comparison done (or muni/co-op situation explained)

Write-Up (450 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ SB 6 large-load point included accurately
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (regulation, deregulation, state vs. federal jurisdiction)

20. The Week the Heat Went Out: Winter Storm Uri

15 POINTS · 2-3 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO LIVED THROUGH WINTER STORM URI — OR KNOW SOMEONE WHO DID

In February 2021, Winter Storm Uri — a once-in-a-generation arctic freeze, not a hurricane and not a heat wave — killed hundreds of Texans, knocked out power and heat to millions for days in sub-freezing temperatures, froze pipes across the state, and exposed every seam in Texas's energy and emergency governance. Interview someone who experienced Uri in Texas — a family member, neighbor, coworker, classmate — and connect their experience to the governmental failures and reforms that followed.

How to Get Started

1. Find your interviewee. Almost any Texan over ~22 has a Uri story. Ask: Where were you? How long without power/water? What did you do? Who did you blame? What, if anything, changed for you?

2. Do the background reading: at least 2 quality retrospectives on Uri's causes (generation failures across sources, gas supply, ERCOT's near-collapse) and the reforms that followed (weatherization mandates, SB 3 of 2021, alert changes).
3. Conduct a 15–20 minute interview, recorded with permission or documented in detailed notes.

Requirements

- One interview with someone who experienced Uri in Texas (15–20 min, documented)
- 5+ prepared questions submitted
- Background research: 2+ credible sources on causes and reforms
- Written piece (600 words minimum) weaving the personal story together with the governance analysis: which institutions failed this person, and what has changed since
- Safety connection: one concrete preparedness step the student has taken or will take, stated specifically

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 15 points

Interview ✓

- ☐ Real interview conducted and documented
- ☐ Interviewee experienced Winter Storm Uri (February 2021) in Texas
- ☐ Prepared questions submitted
- ☐ Specific details from the conversation appear in the write-up

Governance Analysis ✓

- ☐ Causes of the Uri crisis accurately summarized (no single-villain oversimplification)
- ☐ Post-Uri reforms identified (weatherization, SB 3, etc.)
- ☐ Personal story connected to specific institutions (ERCOT, PUC, utilities, local government)

Write-Up (600 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Concrete personal preparedness step stated
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (regulatory failure, reform, intergovernmental response)

21. Who Owns the Water?

12 POINTS · 2 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS INTERESTED IN GROWTH, DROUGHT, AND THE NEXT BIG TEXAS FIGHT

Texas is growing faster than its water supply, and the governance is bizarre: surface water belongs to the state, but groundwater follows the "rule of capture" — moderated by nearly 100 local groundwater conservation districts. Meanwhile, the state water plan projects huge shortfalls, and data centers and new suburbs are all drinking from the same sources. Investigate water governance for YOUR region.

How to Get Started

1. Find your region in the State Water Plan. The Texas Water Development Board's interactive plan (twddb.texas.gov) is organized by regional planning groups — DFW is Region C. Find your region's projected demand vs. supply.
2. Find your groundwater conservation district (if any) — TWDB and TCEQ both map GCDs. (Much of urban Tarrant County is NOT in a GCD — itself a finding worth explaining.)
3. Identify one current local water controversy or project from news: a new reservoir, pipeline, drought restrictions, a subdivision or data center's water demand.

Requirements

- Surface water vs. groundwater legal regimes explained correctly (state ownership vs. rule of capture + GCDs)
- Student's regional planning group identified with one demand/supply projection cited
- GCD status for student's home area documented (which one, or none — and what that means)
- One current local water project/controversy summarized with sources
- Write-up (450 words minimum)

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 12 points

Legal & Institutional Accuracy ✓

- ☐ Surface vs. groundwater regimes correctly distinguished
- ☐ Regional planning group correctly identified with a real projection cited
- ☐ Home-area GCD status correctly documented

Current Events ✓

- ☐ One real, current local water issue summarized with sources
- ☐ Issue connected to the governance structures above

Write-Up (450 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Connects to course concepts (special districts, planning, growth)
- ☐ Local specificity throughout

22. Texas News Connection Journal #1

10 POINTS · 1–1.5 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO FOLLOW CURRENT EVENTS

Connect one Texas state or local government news story from the last 30 days to course concepts and your own life. Strong sources: Texas Tribune, Fort Worth Report, Dallas Morning News, Star-Telegram, KERA, your community's paper.

Requirements

- Article from the last 30 days about TEXAS state or local government (not federal)
- Link to the original article
- Three sections, 150 words each (450 total): summary → course connections → personal/local impact
- One original photo or screenshot showing the local angle, with caption

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 10 points

Article Requirements ✓

- ☐ Published within last 30 days, credible source, link provided
- ☐ Genuinely about Texas state or local government

Written Components (450 words total) ✓

- ☐ Summary (150 words) demonstrates understanding
- ☐ Course connections (150 words) name specific concepts
- ☐ Personal impact (150 words) is specific to the student's life/community

Visual Evidence ✓

- ☐ Relevant photo/screenshot with explanatory caption

23. Texas News Connection Journal #2

10 POINTS · 1–1.5 HOURS

Connect one Texas state or local government news story from the last 30 days to course concepts and your own life. Strong sources: Texas Tribune, Fort Worth Report, Dallas Morning News, Star-Telegram, KERA, your community's paper.

Requirements

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 10 points

Article Requirements ✓

- ☐ Published within last 30 days, credible source, link provided
- ☐ Genuinely about Texas state or local government

Written Components (450 words total) ✓

- ☐ Summary (150 words) demonstrates understanding
- ☐ Course connections (150 words) name specific concepts
- ☐ Personal impact (150 words) is specific to the student's life/community

Visual Evidence ✓

- ☐ Relevant photo/screenshot with explanatory caption

Additional Criteria ✓

- ☐ Different article and distinctly different topic from Journal #1
- ☐ Deeper course connection than #1 (new concept applied)

24. Texan & Their Government Interview Clip #1

10 POINTS · 1–2 HOURS · BEST FOR: STUDENTS BUILDING TOWARD THE FULL INTERVIEW SERIES, OR WHO WANT A LIGHTER INTERVIEW OPTION

A 2–3 minute recorded conversation with any Texan (not a government employee — a regular person) about their actual experiences with Texas state or local government: the DMV—wait, that's not what we call it here (it's the DPS for licenses and the county tax office for registration — and THAT confusion is exactly the kind of thing to talk about), property taxes, schools, courts, city services.

Requirements

- 2–3 minute video or audio clip, recorded with permission
- 3 structured questions about their real experiences with Texas/local government
- Different person than any other TIA interview assignment
- Written analysis (150 words minimum) connecting their experience to a course concept

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 10 points

Clip Requirements ✓

- ☐ 2–3 minutes, audible, recorded with stated permission
- ☐ Interviewee is a real person sharing real Texas government experiences
- ☐ 3 structured questions used

Analysis ✓

- ☐ 150+ word analysis
- ☐ Specific course concept correctly applied to their experience
- ☐ Interviewee's actual words/stories referenced

25. Texan & Their Government Interview Clip #2

10 POINTS · 1-2 HOURS

A 2-3 minute recorded conversation with any Texan (not a government employee — a regular person) about their actual experiences with Texas state or local government: the DMV—wait, that's not what we call it here (it's the DPS for licenses and the county tax office for registration — and THAT confusion is exactly the kind of thing to talk about), property taxes, schools, courts, city services.

Requirements

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 10 points

Clip Requirements ✓

- ☐ 2-3 minutes, audible, recorded with stated permission
- ☐ Interviewee is a real person sharing real Texas government experiences
- ☐ 3 structured questions used

Analysis ✓

- ☐ 150+ word analysis
- ☐ Specific course concept correctly applied to their experience
- ☐ Interviewee's actual words/stories referenced

Additional Criteria ✓

- ☐ Different interviewee and main topic than Clip #1
- ☐ Analysis compares or contrasts with Clip #1's findings

Quick Engagement Activities • 5–8 points each

26. Texas Impact Reflection #1

5 POINTS • 30–45 MINUTES • BEST FOR: EVERYONE — THIS IS THE GATEWAY ASSIGNMENT

Spot one way Texas state or local government touched your life this week — the road you drove, the inspection sticker, the school zone, the library, the water from the tap, the TABC sign at the restaurant — photograph it, and reflect.

Requirements

- Written reflection (150 words minimum) identifying a specific Texas state/local policy, agency, or service
- Explains the concrete impact on YOUR life this week
- Evaluates the impact (positive, negative, mixed) with reasoning
- One original photo taken by you, clearly connected to the reflection
- Names the specific government responsible (not just "the government" — WHICH one)

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 5 points

Written Reflection (150 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Specific Texas state or local government entity correctly named
- ☐ Concrete impact on student's actual life explained
- ☐ Impact evaluated with reasoning
- ☐ Connects to a current course topic

Visual Evidence ✓

- ☐ Original photo taken by student
- ☐ Clear connection between photo and reflection

27. Texas Impact Reflection #2

5 POINTS • 30–45 MINUTES

Spot one way Texas state or local government touched your life this week — the road you drove, the inspection sticker, the school zone, the library, the water from the tap, the TABC sign at the restaurant — photograph it, and reflect.

Requirements

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 5 points

Written Reflection (150 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Specific Texas state or local government entity correctly named
- ☐ Concrete impact on student's actual life explained
- ☐ Impact evaluated with reasoning
- ☐ Connects to a current course topic

Visual Evidence ✓

- ☐ Original photo taken by student
- ☐ Clear connection between photo and reflection

Additional Criteria ✓

- ☐ Different topic and different level of government than #1

28. Texas Impact Reflection #3

5 POINTS · 30–45 MINUTES

Spot one way Texas state or local government touched your life this week — the road you drove, the inspection sticker, the school zone, the library, the water from the tap, the TABC sign at the restaurant — photograph it, and reflect.

Requirements

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 5 points

Written Reflection (150 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Specific Texas state or local government entity correctly named
- ☐ Concrete impact on student's actual life explained
- ☐ Impact evaluated with reasoning
- ☐ Connects to a current course topic

Visual Evidence ✓

- ☐ Original photo taken by student
- ☐ Clear connection between photo and reflection

Additional Criteria ✓

- ☐ New topic, not previously used
- ☐ Sharper analysis than earlier reflections (goes beyond observation to evaluation)

29. Texas Impact Reflection #4

5 POINTS · 30–45 MINUTES

Spot one way Texas state or local government touched your life this week — the road you drove, the inspection sticker, the school zone, the library, the water from the tap, the TABC sign at the restaurant — photograph it, and reflect.

Requirements

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 5 points

Written Reflection (150 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Specific Texas state or local government entity correctly named
- ☐ Concrete impact on student's actual life explained
- ☐ Impact evaluated with reasoning
- ☐ Connects to a current course topic

Visual Evidence ✓

- ☐ Original photo taken by student
- ☐ Clear connection between photo and reflection

Additional Criteria ✓

- ☐ New topic
- ☐ Nuanced understanding demonstrated (trade-offs acknowledged)

30. Texas Impact Reflection #5

5 POINTS · 30–45 MINUTES

Spot one way Texas state or local government touched your life this week — the road you drove, the inspection sticker, the school zone, the library, the water from the tap, the TABC sign at the restaurant — photograph it, and reflect.

Requirements

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 5 points

Written Reflection (150 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ Specific Texas state or local government entity correctly named
- ☐ Concrete impact on student's actual life explained
- ☐ Impact evaluated with reasoning
- ☐ Connects to a current course topic

Visual Evidence ✓

- ☐ Original photo taken by student
- ☐ Clear connection between photo and reflection

Additional Criteria ✓

- ☐ Synthesizes learning across the semester
- ☐ References at least one earlier TIA activity's findings

31. 60-Second Texas Government #1

8 POINTS · 45–60 MINUTES · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO'D RATHER TALK THAN WRITE

A 60-second video explaining one specific way Texas state or local government affected your week — with you on camera and visual evidence of the thing itself.

Requirements

- ~60-second video (55–65 seconds)
- One SPECIFIC Texas state/local government impact, with the responsible entity named
- Visual evidence in the video (show the thing!)
- Connection to a course concept stated out loud
- 2–3 sentence written note identifying the concept used

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 8 points

Video Requirements ✓

- ☐ 55–65 seconds, clear audio
- ☐ Student on camera explaining
- ☐ Visual evidence of the impact included

Content ✓

- ☐ Specific impact and specific responsible Texas government named
- ☐ Course concept stated and correctly applied
- ☐ Personal engagement evident

Documentation ✓

- ☐ Written 2–3 sentence concept note submitted

32. 60-Second Texas Government #2

8 POINTS · 45–60 MINUTES

A 60-second video explaining one specific way Texas state or local government affected your week — with you on camera and visual evidence of the thing itself.

Requirements

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 8 points

Video Requirements ✓

- ☐ 55–65 seconds, clear audio
- ☐ Student on camera explaining
- ☐ Visual evidence of the impact included

Content ✓

- ☐ Specific impact and specific responsible Texas government named
- ☐ Course concept stated and correctly applied
- ☐ Personal engagement evident

Documentation ✓

- ☐ Written 2–3 sentence concept note submitted

Additional Criteria ✓

- ☐ Different topic and government level than Video #1

33. 60-Second Texas Government #3

8 POINTS · 45–60 MINUTES

A 60-second video explaining one specific way Texas state or local government affected your week — with you on camera and visual evidence of the thing itself.

Requirements

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 8 points

Video Requirements ✓

- ☐ 55–65 seconds, clear audio
- ☐ Student on camera explaining
- ☐ Visual evidence of the impact included

Content ✓

- ☐ Specific impact and specific responsible Texas government named

- ☐ Course concept stated and correctly applied
- ☐ Personal engagement evident

Documentation ✓

- ☐ Written 2–3 sentence concept note submitted

Additional Criteria ✓

- ☐ Unique content from previous videos
- ☐ Multiple course connections made

34. 60-Second Texas Government #4

8 POINTS · 45–60 MINUTES

A 60-second video explaining one specific way Texas state or local government affected your week — with you on camera and visual evidence of the thing itself.

Requirements

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 8 points

Video Requirements ✓

- ☐ 55–65 seconds, clear audio
- ☐ Student on camera explaining
- ☐ Visual evidence of the impact included

Content ✓

- ☐ Specific impact and specific responsible Texas government named
- ☐ Course concept stated and correctly applied
- ☐ Personal engagement evident

Documentation ✓

- ☐ Written 2–3 sentence concept note submitted

Additional Criteria ✓

- ☐ New topic
- ☐ Most polished delivery of the series; clear growth from Video #1

35. Meet Your Officials

6 POINTS · 45–60 MINUTES · BEST FOR: EVERYONE — MOST STUDENTS CANNOT CURRENTLY NAME THEIR COMMISSIONER OR STATE REP

Build your complete personal representation roster, from constable to governor, using your actual address.

How to Get Started

1. Who Represents Me (wrm.capitol.texas.gov) gives your state rep, state senator, SBOE member, and congressional delegation from your address.
2. Your county website for: county judge, your precinct's commissioner, constable, and justice of the peace.
3. Your city website for: mayor and your council district's member (find your district on the city's district map).
4. Your ISD for your school board (trustees may be at-large or single-member — note which).

Requirements

- Complete roster for YOUR address: city council member + mayor; county judge + your commissioner + your JP + your constable; school board; state rep + state senator; governor + lt. governor (and note SBOE member)
- Screenshot of your Who Represents Me results
- For any 3 officials: next election year for that seat
- 150-word reflection: which of these did you not know, and which one's job most directly affects you?

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 6 points

Roster Accuracy ✓

- ☐ All listed offices included and correct for the student's actual address
- ☐ District/precinct numbers included where applicable
- ☐ Who Represents Me screenshot provided

Engagement ✓

- ☐ Next election years found for 3 officials
- ☐ 150-word reflection completed with genuine specifics

36. Texas Constitution Oddity Spotlight

6 POINTS · 45–60 MINUTES · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO APPRECIATE THE WEIRD

The Texas Constitution of 1876 has been amended over 500 times and contains genuine oddities. Find one specific provision or amendment that strikes you as strange, hyper-specific, or surprising, and explain it.

How to Get Started

1. Browse the Texas Constitution on the Legislature's statutes site (statutes.capitol.texas.gov) or the Legislative Reference Library's amendment history.
2. Good hunting grounds: Article III's pages of specific exceptions; Article XVI's miscellany; recent amendment elections (each November of odd years brings a fresh crop of hyper-specific propositions).
3. Pick ONE provision; quote or accurately paraphrase it; find out WHY it's in there (amendment history, news coverage of the election that passed it).

Requirements

- One specific constitutional provision quoted/cited accurately (article, section, or amendment year)
- The backstory: why it exists, when adopted, what problem it solved (or created)
- Explanation of why such detail lands in the CONSTITUTION rather than statute (the statute-like constitution problem)
- 300 words minimum

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 6 points

Accuracy ✓

- ☐ Real provision correctly cited
- ☐ Backstory researched with at least 1 credible source
- ☐ No misstatements of what the provision does

Analysis (300 words minimum) ✓

- ☐ Meets word count
- ☐ "Why is this in a constitution?" question engaged seriously

[] Connects to course concepts (constitutional design, amendment process, 1876 framers' distrust of government)

37. Sign of Government

5 POINTS · 30 MINUTES · BEST FOR: A FIRST TOE IN THE WATER

One photo. One piece of visible public infrastructure or signage — water tower, road sign, fire station, historical marker, ESD sign, library, drainage project sign — traced to the specific government that owns or operates it.

Requirements

- One original photo taken by you in your community
- Caption (100 words minimum): what it is, WHICH government runs it, how you verified that, and what that government's broader job is
- Must not duplicate a photo used in any other TIA assignment

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 5 points

Criteria ✓

- [] Original, local photo by the student
- [] Correct specific government identified (not generic)
- [] Verification method stated
- [] 100+ word caption connecting to that government's role
- [] Photo not reused from another assignment

38. Emergency Ready in 60

8 POINTS · 45–60 MINUTES · BEST FOR: STUDENTS WHO WANT A FAST, GENUINELY USEFUL SAFETY WIN

Three rapid actions that make you measurably more disaster-ready, documented: (1) register for your county/city emergency alerts, (2) identify your area's top hazard from official sources, (3) record a 60-second video telling a friend or family member how to do the same.

How to Get Started

1. Your county Office of Emergency Management page links the official alert registration (and explains the outdoor siren policy).
2. ready.texas.gov (TDEM) and your county OEM list regional hazards.
3. Film the 60-second "do this now" explainer — point your viewer to the actual sign-up.

Requirements

- Screenshot proof of alert registration (yours, this semester)
- Top local hazard identified from an official source (cited)
- 60-second video (55–65 sec) teaching someone to register, naming the actual local system
- 2–3 sentence note connecting emergency alerts to which governments run them

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 8 points

Actions Taken ✓

- [] Alert registration completed and documented this semester
- [] Top hazard identified from an official local/state source

Video ✓

- ☐ 55–65 seconds, clear audio, student on camera
- ☐ Names the actual local alert system and shows/states where to sign up
- ☐ Accurate information throughout

Connection ✓

- ☐ Written note correctly identifies the responsible government(s)

39. Agenda Decoder

6 POINTS · 45 MINUTES · BEST FOR: STUDENTS PREPARING FOR A HIGHER EFFORT MEETING ASSIGNMENT — OR ANYONE CURIOUS

Local government agendas are public, posted 72 hours ahead under the Texas Open Meetings Act — and written in a dialect of bureaucratese. Find one upcoming agenda (city council, school board, or commissioners court near you) and translate three items into plain English.

How to Get Started

1. Find the "Agendas & Minutes" page for any local body near you (cities and counties almost all use portals like Legistar, CivicClerk, or PDF postings).
2. Pick an agenda for a meeting that hasn't happened yet.
3. Choose 3 items — at least one involving money — and decode them: what is actually being decided, who's affected, what would a YES do?

Requirements

- Screenshot/link of an upcoming (not past) agenda from a body near you
- 3 items translated to plain English (one involving money/contracts)
- For each: what's being decided, who's affected, and one question a resident should ask
- Note the Open Meetings Act posting requirement and where you found the posting

Complete/Incomplete Rubric — COMPLETE = all criteria met = 6 points

Agenda Work ✓

- ☐ Genuine upcoming agenda from a real nearby body, documented
- ☐ 3 items decoded accurately, including one financial item
- ☐ Translations are plain-English and correct

Civic Literacy ✓

- ☐ A resident-question posed for each item
- ☐ Open Meetings Act posting requirement correctly noted